

A FIELD GUIDE TO EMAIL COPY THAT SELLS

BURN YOUR THESAURUS

5 hard rules from **\$5M+** in email revenue



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BEFORE WE START

Who's Telling You This?

I'm Wil. Over the past decade I've written and deployed thousands of emails as the copy chief for DTC ecommerce brands – **\$10M+ in tracked funnel revenue**, with email programs holding \$50K+/week for years at a stretch, plus an SMS program I built from zero to \$20K+/week.

“As a guy who built an affiliate company, solely through email, from \$0 to \$300,000 every month – if I could choose 1 guy to do it again with from scratch, I'd choose Wil.”

LOU COZZOLINO

“Going on seven years now, I don't think there's anybody better when it comes to writing front-end copy, email copy, and even SMS copy.”

ADAM LANTELME • SICURO BRANDS

A lot of these lessons I had to learn the hard way... this book is to help ensure YOU don't have to do that. :)

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READ THIS FIRST

The Offer Beats the Words

Before any rule about writing, one rule about reality.

Gary Halbert said no amount of clarity will make a bad offer better. He was right. If a promotion is dying, suspect the offer, the market, or the timing *before* you suspect the wording.

Everything in this book is the last mile. It makes a good offer convert harder. It cannot resurrect a dead one.

One more thing to hold onto the whole way through: **a promo email has exactly one job – the click.**

You are not selling the product in the inbox. You're pulling the most compelling beats out of the sales page and compressing them into a snapshot that makes NOT clicking feel impossible.

Sell the click. Let the page sell the product.

Now the rules.

RULE N° 1

Every Email Gets ONE Angle

Most marketers have a stronger focus muscle than the average person.

So they wrongly assume readers can juggle multiple ideas to piece together what you're saying. They write like they're Matt Damon scratching on a chalkboard in *Good Will Hunting*.

Big mistake. :/

Your reader barely has headspace for one thing – because your email is competing with everything else in their day. Once you have their attention, **lock down like a vice grip**.

For example... say you're selling a fitness smartwatch. There are loads of real reasons people want one:

- It tracks sleep, heart rate, and recovery automatically.
- The battery lasts two weeks, not two days.
- It's waterproof enough for the pool.
- It costs less than one month with a personal trainer.
- It can catch heart-rhythm problems early.
- It looks like a normal watch in a meeting.

An amateur thinks: *look at all these benefits I can front-load into my email!!*

That won't work. Pick ONE. Build the subject line on it. Spend the first 3-4 lines making it vivid. Bullet the rest near the bottom if you must.

What makes an angle a BIG idea

A big idea is **a strong benefit tied to something the reader hasn't heard before**. Both halves matter.

Benefit with no novelty sounds like every competitor, and the reader's brain files it under "seen it." Novelty with no benefit is trivia.

The test: does the angle make the reader curious AND make them want something? If it only does one, keep digging.

Lead with one of: Problem, Promise, or Proof

Nearly every winning email leads with one of these three, even when it contains all three:

- **Problem-led** – the hidden cause of their frustration. A fresh villain that isn't their fault.
- **Promise-led** – the outcome, or an exciting new way to get it.
- **Proof-led** – a result, a story, a demonstration.

Deciding which one you're leading with, *before you write a word*, kills most focus problems on its own.

And one angle per email doesn't mean one angle per product. Rotate. Over a month the list hears every selling point you have – one clean swing at a time – and your results tell you exactly which angles pull, because nothing muddled the test.

RULE N° 2

Your Subject Line Is a Promise. Keep It Immediately.

The simplest fix in this book: **inject your subject line into the very first line of body copy.**

If the subject line's job is to get opens, the first line's job is to make them keep reading. The reader opened ON the subject line's promise – so the first thing they read has to pay it off, or the open feels like a bait-and-switch.

Here's what that looks like, with a subject line of *"The 60-second fix for terrible sleep"*:

WEAK

"Hope your week is going great!"

STRONG

"Here's the 60-second fix for the worst night of sleep you keep having on Sundays."

Same subject line. One email keeps its promise immediately. The other breaks it – this send, and quietly, every send after it. That's how list fatigue actually starts: not frequency... *broken promises at frequency.*

What makes the promise worth opening

The formula behind almost every subject line I've seen win: **curiosity + a big promise, felt as NEW.**

Curiosity alone isn't enough. A pure mystery with no hint of a payoff gets a shrug. Read your subject line and ask: *"ok... but who cares?"* If you can't answer instantly, kill it.

The fix is to name the payoff or the stakes inside the curiosity. "The thing top performers do" is a shrug. "The 5-minute habit behind every top performer's morning" gives the curiosity a reason to matter.

And if you use a preheader, its only job is to widen the gap the subject line opened. Tease the payoff – at the preview pane, all the reader knows is the subject line.

Stop “Throat Clearing” In Your Leads

The biggest issue I see from inexperienced copywriters.

Even with a solid angle, they waste the lead warming up – *and totally lose the reader’s attention.*

Say we’re writing an email for a fat-loss supplement. A lot of copywriters start like this:

“Everybody knows how hard it is to lose weight. You eat salads for dinner five times per week... you spend hours on the stair-climber... but nothing ever changes.

It’s so frustrating.”

That’s throat clearing – extraneous things people already know that do nothing to pull them in. Replace all of it with one line:

“In 2 seconds, you’re going to see the #1 clinically-backed weight loss solution for everyone who’s wasted years on diet and exercise with nothing to show for it.”

Three openings that never clear their throat

- **Drop into a moment.** Open mid-scene, like a movie cold open. A specific instant, not a summary – now they want to know what happens next.
- **The invisible difference.** Two people, identical in every way except one thing – and that one thing put them on wildly different paths. Don’t name it in the lead. The email exists to reveal it.
- **A question they can’t answer.** A real question whose answer isn’t obvious – ideally where something “good” is secretly causing their problem. If the average reader can guess it, it failed.

Two more lead killers

Don't spend the lead on what the thing ISN'T. A lead is prime real estate: spend it on the payoff. A contrast earns one line as a yardstick, then pivot straight to the stakes.

Enter the conversation already in their head. The reader is mid-thought. Meet the objection they're already having ("if this sounds too good, I get it") instead of the one you wish they had.

RULE N° 4

Don't Be Clever & "Kill Your Darlings"

Copywriting isn't stand-up comedy.

Sure, you might entertain a bit naturally if you're in-tune with your audience, but we're writing to earn sales... not chuckles.

Follow Stephen King's advice, and "kill your darlings."

If you write something and think to yourself... *damn that's clever*.

It's probably weighing down your copy and distracting from the offer. So kill it! 

The delete test

Delete the clever line. If the email loses selling power, keep it. If it only loses entertainment... it was a darling.

Chekhov's gun, for copy

If a detail doesn't get fired later – if it doesn't set up the offer, the proof, or the close – don't hang it on the wall. Every sentence either moves the reader toward the click or slows them on the way to it.

Write it tight. Then cut another 5-10%. There's always another 5-10%.

The bar to clear

Before anything ships, hold it to this: would a veteran marketer who knows this audience believe a sharp human copywriter wrote it – someone who genuinely gets this market?

If it reads generic, templated, or machine-average, it's dead on arrival. The inbox is a room full of people who've seen every trick. Sounding like a real person is the price of entry.

Burn Your Thesaurus

Even if you’re writing for a sophisticated audience, the simple truth is you’re not writing to other copy nerds.

You’re writing to regular people – and regular people don’t like thinking too much.

So don’t make them think!!

If you can’t make your point without five dollar words, **you don’t understand the point yet.**

For example, selling a knife sharpener:

WEAK	<i>“Experience unparalleled culinary precision through our proprietary honing geometry.”</i>
STRONG	<i>“Twenty seconds a side. Your knife shaves paper again.”</i>

The register: a friend talking to a friend

Write how the reader talks to a close friend at lunch. Short sentences. Short words – “show,” not “demonstrate.” Mix the rhythm and let a 2-word sentence land after a long one. Like this.

Keep paragraphs to one or two sentences. A paragraph that breaks past three lines kills the scan – and email is read at a glance or not at all.

Never make anything sound like work

This one prints money and almost nobody follows it.

Everything on the reader’s end is easy. The product does the hard part; the reader just says yes, shows up, claims it.

Kill the effort words: “learn,” “master,” “figure out,” “do the math.” Swap in the light-touch versions: “discover,” “get,” “it’s already handled.” “Do the math” reads as homework... “we did the hard part for you” reads as easy.

Make Them SEE It

The five rules keep an email focused, honest, and readable. These last three chapters are what make one *convert*.

The first is the highest-value craft skill in direct response: turning a flat claim into something the reader sees and feels. I call it **making the mind-movie**.

Vague gets ignored. Every pain and every benefit must be so situational and concrete that the reader sees their own life in it:

FLAT	<i>“Lose weight” • “Sleep better” • “Save time”</i>
VIVID	<i>“The jeans in the back of your closet fit again” • “You stop dreading 3am, because you haven’t seen it in weeks” • “You’re done before the coffee finishes brewing”</i>

Go one layer deeper than most writers stop

Most copy states the claim, adds a few vivid descriptions, and quits. The conversion lives in the two layers underneath:

- **The mind-movie** – actual events that will happen. Not “you’ll feel confident” but the moment: what they see in the mirror, what they do that they couldn’t do before.
- **The identity payoff** – how it changes the way they see themselves, and how others see them. Status is the deepest driver. Name how specific people in their life react.

Two patterns to steal

Triplets. Present benefits in threes, and make the three genuinely different – one practical, one about family or friends, one about who they become. Three distinct doors; the reader walks through the one that’s theirs.

The “or...” cascade. A ladder of small everyday wins that closes on identity: *“Maybe you finally take the stairs without thinking about it... or say yes to the weekend trip... or just like what you see in the mirror.”*

Prove It As You Say It

A claim without proof is a request to be doubted.

The old-school standard – Gary Bencivenga’s – is a 1:1 ratio: **every claim travels with its proof**, ideally in the same sentence. You won’t always hit 1:1. Aim at it anyway.

Proof comes in more flavors than testimonials:

- **Names and numbers.** Exact ones. “Cut review time to 15 minutes” beats “much faster” every single time. Oddly specific beats round: 14 minutes is more believable than 15.
- **Testable proof.** Something the reader can verify from their own life, instantly: “*That’s why gyms are packed in January and empty in July.*” The reader nods – and now they’re agreeing with you. Gold, and almost nobody uses it.
- **Reason-why.** Attach a “because” to every fact. Claims with reasons read as explanations; claims without them read as slogans.
- **Candor.** Admit what the product doesn’t do, or meet the reader’s skepticism head-on: “I know how this sounds. Here’s why it’s true anyway.” Conceding one point buys belief for the next ten.

And the iron rule underneath all of it: **never fabricate proof.** No invented numbers, no imaginary experts, no “studies show.” If you don’t have the proof for a claim... cut the claim. A hallucinated statistic doesn’t just kill the email. It kills the list’s trust in everything you send after it.

Give the Deal a Reason

An unexplained discount reads as a catch.

When the reader sees 40% off with no explanation, some quiet part of their brain asks what’s wrong with it. Overstock? Discontinued? Was the “full price” ever real?

So tell them WHY the deal exists. A season ending. A milestone. New inventory forcing the old out. A thank-you to the list before the public gets it. Any honest reason works – and there is always an honest reason, because the deal exists for one.

Place it right before or with the offer reveal, one or two lines. The same discount with a stated reason converts measurably better than the naked number. It’s one of the cheapest wins in email.

While you’re at it: sell the after-state, not the transaction

The close isn’t where selling stops. A call-to-action that names the payoff (“Get your *Sundays back*”) outpulls “Shop now” because it’s a doorway to the mind-movie you built – the last thing they feel before the click.

The Pre-Send Checklist

Everything above, compressed into the pass I run on a finished draft. One pass at a time – don't try to hold all nine in your head while writing. **Write hot, edit cold.**

- 1 One angle?** Subject line, lead, and body all serve a single big idea. Anything serving a second idea moves to another send.
- 2 Promise kept?** First body line echoes the subject line. Preheader teases – without leaning on anything the reader hasn't seen.
- 3 Lead clean?** No warm-up, no “what this isn't,” no telling them what they already know. Payoff or tension by line one.
- 4 Darlings dead?** Run the delete test on your favorite line. Chekhov's gun on every detail. Then cut 5-10% more.
- 5 Plain words?** Friend-at-lunch register. Paragraphs of one or two sentences. Nothing sounds like work for the reader.
- 6 Vivid?** The big pain and the big benefit each got a mind-movie moment, not just an adjective.
- 7 Proven?** Every claim travels with proof – a number, a testable fact, a because. Nothing fabricated, ever.
- 8 Reason for the deal?** The discount has an honest why, stated near the offer.
- 9 Read it aloud.** Anywhere you stumble, the reader stops. Fix the stumble, ship it, and let the results – not your taste – pick the winners.

READY FOR MORE?

Keep the Fire Going

Everything I write starts with these rules. If this helped:

See the receipts

Work samples, testimonials, and my full resume live at
<https://wilcleave.land>

Want this applied to your list?

Grab a call slot: calendly.com/wccleaveland

Building an email program in-house?

I take full-time roles too. Resume's on the site.

Cheers to more sales!

– Wil